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How to Make an Americano

by [Sonja Overhiser](#)

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Learn **how to make an Americano** with this simple step-by-step guide! This classic espresso drink takes just minutes to make at home.



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When it comes to espresso drinks, the one I reach for most often is the classic Americano. A shot of bitter and dark espresso tastes incredible, but smooth it out with water as a Caffè Americano and it smooths the bitter flavor into something altogether new!

I've made hundreds of coffee drinks at home, and after months of testing I've perfected the perfect Americano. If you've ever ordered one at a coffee shop

and thought “I could make this myself,” you’re absolutely right. Here’s everything you need to know for how to make an Americano at home!

What’s an Americano?

An Americano is an espresso drink made with hot water and espresso, also called a Caffè Americano. The drink can be made with either one or two shots of espresso, and varying ratios of water.

Diluting the strong dark espresso roast brings the flavor closer to a drip coffee, which might be where the name originated! “Americano” means American in Italian or Spanish, referring to the coffee’s strength being closer to an American-style drip coffee.

Does an Americano have milk? *Never*. A true Americano does not include milk like a latte, cappuccino, or macchiato. You can add milk if you like, but then it’s not the true form of this drink.

The Water-to-Espresso Ratio

How much water is an Americano? Great question, and one that has more than one answer. There are various ratios that are considered acceptable:

- **The typical Caffè Americano ratio is 2:1.** That’s 2 parts hot water to 1 part espresso. This ratio makes the drink still taste dark and bitter, like a lightened form of espresso. Ad ends in 10
- **Use 3:1 for a smoother, milder coffee with more volume.** This ratio makes the Americano taste like a bitter drip coffee. (If you order an Americano at Starbucks, it will taste like this ratio. I personally prefer 2:1.)
- **You can customize the water to taste.** Every barista and coffee shop makes an Americano differently.



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What You Need to Make an Americano

How to make an Americano? You'll need the following:

- **Espresso roast coffee:** This is important to get the right dark, bitter flavor. Look for espresso roast or dark roast coffee for the most bold, classic flavor. Buy whole beans and grind them right before brewing.
- **Espresso machine or espresso maker:** There are several ways to make an espresso! We use an [espresso machine](#) ↗, which sits on a countertop. You can use a small [manual espresso maker](#) ↗ too: it's cheaper and portable. You can also make [French Press espresso](#) (which has great flavor). For more details, go to my guide on [How to Make Espresso \(5 Ways\)](#).

How to Make an Americano: Step by Step

Once you know about the water ratio and espresso technique: there's not much to know about this [coffee drink](#)! Here are the basic steps for how to make an Americano:

- **Decide on your drink size.** A 1-shot Americano can mostly fit in an espresso mug. A 2-shot drink is best suited in a latte mug.
- **Make the espresso.** Use espresso roast coffee. Ad ends in 10spresso using your favorite method: with an automated [espresso machine](#) ↗, [manual espresso maker](#) ↗, or [French press](#). Go to [How to Make Espresso \(5 Ways\)](#) for details. (The linked espresso machine is the one I use every day and it works wonderfully.)
- **Boil the water.** Use a regular or electric teapot to boil the water, or use the hot water spout or steam wand on your espresso maker. The standard ratio is 2:1 water to espresso, but you can go up to as much as 3:1.

- **Mix the two and enjoy.** Pour the boiling water into the espresso. Instant Caffè Americano!



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Americano Variations to Try

Once you've mastered the classic, here's where it gets fun:

- **Iced Americano:** Pull your espresso, let it cool briefly, then pour over a glass of ice. Add cold water. Go to my [Iced Americano](#) recipe.
- **Long Black:** This is an Australian/New Zealand spin where the water goes in the cup first, then the espresso is poured over. It preserves the crema topping .
- **Americano with a splash of milk:** It's technically not a "true" Americano, but adding about 1 tablespoon cold milk softens the bitterness.
- **Red Eye:** A red eye is brewed drip coffee with a shot of espresso poured in. See my [Red Eye Coffee](#) recipe. (Personally, I like an Americano much better.)

If you're wondering, the [Americano Cocktail](#) is not related to the coffee drink at all: it's a bitter and bubbly [Campari drink](#)!



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Serving Suggestions

An Americano pairs well with any type of breakfast food, but here are a few of my favorites:

- A slice of toasted [sourdough bread](#) with butter
- A simple breakfast pastry or [blueberry muffin](#)
- As a mid-afternoon pick-me-up before something sweet
- In place of a [pour over coffee](#) when you want something quicker but equally satisfying
- After dinner with a chocolate dessert like [flourless chocolate cake](#)

Frequently Asked Questions

What's the difference between an Americano and drip coffee?



Is an Americano stronger than regular coffee?



Can I make an Americano without an espresso machine?



What's the difference between an Americano and a lungo?



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How to Make an Americano

★★★★★ 4.6 from 7 reviews

Here's how to make an Americano, aka Caffè Americano! This popular coffee drink smooths the bitterness of espresso with hot water.

Author: [Sonja Overhiser](#)

Prep Time: 5 minutes

Cook Time: 0 minutes

Total Time: 5 minutes

Yield: 1 drink

Category: Coffee

Method: Espresso

Cuisine: Coffee

Diet: Vegan

PIN RECIPE

Ingredients

SCALE

- 2 ounces (2 shots) espresso*
- 4 ounces hot water

Instructions



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1. **Make the espresso:** Make the espresso using an espresso machine, manual espresso maker, French press, or Moka Pot. Go to [How to Make Espresso](#) for instructions.
2. **Add hot water:** Heat water using your espresso machine or in a tea pot to about 190 degrees Fahrenheit. Pour it into the espresso. Enjoy!

Notes

^If desired, you can adjust the level of boiling water to your tastes. Go up to 6 ounces boiling water for a flavor that's closer to drip coffee than espresso.

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More Espresso Drinks to Master

This is another post in my **Barista Series**: how to make all your favorite [coffee drinks](#) at home! Here are a few [espresso drinks](#) and [tea lattes](#) to master:

- [Latte](#)
- [Mocha](#)
- [Macchiato](#)
- [Flat White](#) or [Cappuccino](#)
- [Cortado](#) or [Gibraltar](#)
- [Coffee Soda](#)



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About the authors



Alex & Sonja

Hi there! We're Alex & Sonja Overhiser, authors of two cookbooks, busy parents, and a real life couple who

cooks together. We founded the A Couple Cooks website in 2010 to share simple, seasonal recipes and the joy of cooking. We now offer thousands of original recipes, cooking tips, and meal planning ideas—all written and photographed by the two of us (and tested on our kids!).

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REPLY

February 24, 2026 at 9:35 pm

This is so funny. I've moved to South Florida for the winters from Pennsylvania. In Pa, when we want a cup of coffee , we ask for a cup of coffee. In South Florida the only thing that resembles a cup of coffee is Americano- I am thrilled to know what it actually is. Thanks for the recipe and explaining it.

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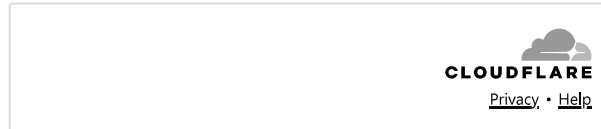
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